muskets there were no easy gains to be made by any of the tribes. An estimated 20,000 Maori warriors died in the Musket Wars, possibly one in five of the entire population.

LAND WARS

In 1840 Britain took over New Zealand as a colony, after agreeing the Treaty of Waitangi with the Maori. Within five years the first of a string of conflicts had broken out in which Maori tribes contested the rule of the British authorities and resisted land grabs by European settlers. Although the Maori King Movement attempted to unify resistance from 1858, there were always Maori who fought on the British side (known as *kupapa*), mostly motivated by tribal rivalry. Yet despite their divisions, the Maori proved among the most effective opponents the British army faced in its 19th-century colonial campaigns. This was despite a lack of numbers – for a combination of British troops, settler militias, and *kupapa* could usually assemble a larger force than Maori rebels could field. Maori weaponry was also inferior; although they obtained rifle muskets, they often had no proper ammunition, resorting to home-made substitutes.

Maori warriors proved adept at guerrilla warfare, but they were also surprisingly successful at adapting their fortified strongholds to the demands of modern warfare. They created *pa* encircled with complex systems of earthworks and palisades, constructed to give entrenched defenders effective fields of fire against enemy infantry attempting an assault. Deep bunkers were dug inside the fort to allow the Maori to survive artillery fire. They invited the British to attack them in these fortified positions, which they would abandon once they had inflicted maximum casualties on the attackers. The strength of this system was demonstrated on 29 April 1864 at Gate Pa, Tauranga. Less than 250 Maori inside the fort faced 1,700 soldiers under General Duncan Cameron equipped with mortars, howitzers, and Armstrong guns. Cameron's artillery destroyed the fort's palisade, but his soldiers suffered heavy casualties in a failed attempt to storm the line of trenches. The Maori staged a strategic withdrawal from the *pa* with only slight losses.



Intricate carving is an important part of Maori culture

Sacred feeding funnel
The *kumete* is a ceremonial food vessel used to feed a warrior after his face had been tattooed. His scars were so severe from tattooing that he was unable to chew for several days; his food was therefore pounded to a paste and taken through the funnel. The contents of the *kumete* were not to be touched by others.

Battle ready
A modern-day Maori in traditional costume perfoms the *haka*. He is armed with a *taiaha* (long staff) used for stabbing and striking, and a *wahaika* (short-range club), secured inside a war belt.

In the 1860s Christian-inspired prophet-led Maori movements erupted, whose followers waged a guerrilla war that seriously threatened the colonists' hold on North Island. In 1868, Titokowaru's forces won two victories defending forts against colonial militia and *kupapa*, and a warband led by Ti Kooti massacred settlers at Matawhero. Yet Titokowaru's rebellion disintegrated the following year, while Ti Kooti's band struggled on as isolated raiders until 1872.

ENDURING TRADITION

The Maori had proved that they could match the Europeans as fighters, but not in their capacity for large-scale economic organization and sustained campaigning. Altogether these colonial conflicts were far less murderous than the Musket Wars, costing the lives of around 2,000 Maori rebels and some 750 British soldiers, settlers, and *kupapa*.

The Maori warrior ethic was not entirely lost after the pacification of New Zealand. A Maori Pioneer battalion served in World War I and a volunteer battalion was organized to fight as part of the New Zealand Expeditionary Force in World War II. The Maori performed with distinction in the Mediterranean theatre, including Greece, Crete, North Africa, and Italy. The men who fought in the desert at El Alamein and on the slopes of Monte Cassino were keenly aware of fulfilling the traditions of their ancestors.